

15. Source: Meeting with the tribespeople

As they waited for the scheduled meeting with the tribal leaders, the Health for All (HfA) delegation took a bold step by attempting to visit the detained international staff at their residence. They believe that their forthcoming appointment with the tribal leaders would act as a safety net, preventing any unwarranted action from the tribespeople. This move was intended to symbolize the delegation's assertiveness and commitment to securing the staff's release.

As they approached the vicinity of the residence, the HfA car was halted by a group of armed individuals who encircled the vehicle. The leader of this group, introducing himself as a local commander, queried the delegation about the intent behind this unscheduled visit. In response, the head of the delegation clarified the wish of the HfA team to check on the wellbeing of their colleagues in the residence, ensuring their safety and care. The commander, however, expressed his reservations, emphasizing that he hadn't received any directives from the tribal leaders regarding such a visit. He proceeded to make a call to the tribal leaders.

Despite the evident opposition, the delegation persisted, proposing a compromise — a brief encounter with the head surgeon outside the premises. Their persistence was met with visible annoyance from the local commander, who explicitly demanded their departure from the area. The atmosphere grew tense as the armed tribespeople, seemingly agitated by the situation, began loading their firearms in an overt display of hostility.

Recognizing the escalating danger and the potential threat to their safety, the delegation made the prudent decision to retreat, promptly leaving the tense scene.